

Conformity without Humiliation Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 20-30 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	conformity-without-humiliation

Big idea: Consensus can distort judgement.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students examine how group information can influence individual judgement.

Student Prompt

Inspect Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A low-stakes line-length or preference task with planted majority responses. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Silent voting before and after seeing a group trend. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Conformity without Humiliation Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A norms debrief focused on method and ethics rather than embarrassment. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Consensus can distort judgement.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Is consensus a reliable guide to truth?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Human Sciences.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how consensus can distort judgement.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Is consensus a reliable guide to truth?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A low-stakes line-length or preference task with planted majority responses.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- A low-stakes line-length or preference task with planted majority responses.
- Silent voting before and after seeing a group trend.
- A norms debrief focused on method and ethics rather than embarrassment.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/conformity-without-humiliation/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/conformity-without-humiliation/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/conformity-without-humiliation/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Students first make a private estimate.
2. Show a fake or real class average that is clearly high or low.
3. Students make a second estimate.
4. Compare how many shifted towards the group. Debrief immediately.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Is consensus a reliable guide to truth?

- When does shared knowledge become groupthink?
- How can communities improve or distort individual knowledge?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...